

Discospondylitis

What is it?

Discospondylitis is an **infection of the disc** between two vertebrae and the bone around it. Bacteria or fungi usually travel through the bloodstream from elsewhere — the urinary tract, skin, heart valves or mouth. Untreated, it can spread to the spinal cord's covering (meningitis) or weaken the spine.

Signs

- **Spinal pain** — the main sign
- Fever, poor appetite, weight loss
- As it worsens: pus buildup, slipped vertebrae or fracture can press on the spinal cord, causing **weakness, wobbliness or paralysis**

Diagnosis

- **Imaging:** X-rays may not show changes until signs have been present for **2–6 weeks**. **MRI** finds the disease earlier, before major bone damage.
- **Finding the infection:** urinalysis and urine culture, blood cultures, **Brucella** test and other infectious disease tests. Sometimes the source is never found.

Until the Brucella result is back, avoid contact with your pet's urine (wear gloves, wash hands). Brucella can infect people.

Treatment

- **Antibiotics** (bacterial) or **antifungals** (fungal), chosen based on test results
- **Pain relief** — anti-inflammatories (usually NSAIDs)
- **Keep giving medication even when your pet seems well.** Bacterial infections need antibiotics for **at least 6 months**.
- **STRICT REST** — the infected disc can make the spine unstable and lead to a fracture. No running, jumping or rough play.

Monitoring

- Follow-up **MRI or CT in 3–4 months**, or spinal X-rays every 6–8 weeks
- **C-reactive protein (CRP)** blood test every 3–4 months — it can detect a relapse before signs return

Outlook

Most dogs respond quickly to pain medication and antibiotics. Prognosis depends on severity (pain only vs. unable to walk), type of infection and response to treatment. **Fungal** infections may need lifelong medication and carry a more guarded outlook. Some cases do not respond, leading to uncontrolled pain and declining quality of life.

Call us if

Pain returns, fever, weakness or trouble walking, or your pet stops eating.